DEPARTMENT OF THE AIR FORCE
SQUADRON OFFICER SCHOOL

2 July 2026

MEMORANDUM FOR SOS FACULTY, STAFF, AND STUDENTS

FROM: SOS/CC

SUBJECT: Generative AI Usage Policy Memo, Academic Year 2026-2027

1. To promote consistency, transparency, and academic integrity across Squadron Officer School (SOS), the Commandant is establishing standardized expectations and language for the use of Generative Artificial Intelligence (GenAI) in academic contexts. Without such consistency, differences across courses may lead to confusion and unintentional violations of academic standards. This policy applies to all students and faculty. AI must remain a tool to accelerate comprehension and enhance cognitive command rather than serve as a replacement for human-driven leadership.

2. The attached Guidance for Academic GenAI Usage outlines a framework of GenAI usage and serves as the official policy describing the communication of permissible GenAI use in SOS courses.

a. The Dean of Faculty is required to designate the permissible students GenAI usage level(s) (0–6) for each assignment or for their course overall using the attached framework. Instructors may tailor GenAI expectations for specific assignments (e.g., which GenAI to use), but must clearly communicate those expectations to Students.

b. The Dean of SOS is required to designate the permitted faculty GenAI usage level(s) for assignment reviews and curriculum generation. Instructors must clearly communicate those expectations to students. Instructors shall not utilize GenAI for determination of final grades.

3. We support SOS's commitment to academic excellence, ethical leadership, and responsible integration of emerging technologies. Through increased AI literacy, student and faculty's time can be used more efficiently. When used thoughtfully and transparently, it can deepen understanding, improve efficiency, and cultivate the intellectual agility essential to our profession.

STEVEN J. AYRE, Colonel, USAF
Commandant

Attachment:
Guidance for GenAI Usage

Guidance for Academic-GenAI Usage (AY 26-27)

Generative AI (GenAI) tools are readily available and can provide support for both instructors and Students, better enabling them to innovate and improve efficiency. However, inappropriate use of GenAI may reduce learning, and AI products may incorporate errors due to “hallucinations” and bias resulting from the datasets used to train the GenAI. Thus, both Captains and faculty can benefit from clear statements regarding expectations and best practices related to GenAI use, how to verify and document such use, and how to ethically use GenAI.

For purposes of this document, traditional spellcheck and grammar check tools are not considered to be GenAI. They use fixed dictionaries and grammar rules to identify localized problems and offer suggested fixes to those problems; however, they do not provide the larger-scale sentence rewriting that is possible with GenAI. Unless otherwise noted by an instructor, these non-GenAI tools are permissible and not considered to be part of the levels of use described below

Section 1: Definitions and Terminology

To establish a standardized, school-wide vocabulary, the following definitions must be utilized in all SOS course syllabi, faculty guides, and academic briefings.

Core AI Terms

Term	Simple Definition
Artificial Intelligence (AI)	Computer systems that perform tasks typically requiring human intelligence.
Generative AI (GenAI)	AI that creates new content such as text, images, audio, video, or code. *Not to be confused from GenAI.mil
Large Language Model (LLM)	A type of AI trained on large amounts of text to understand and generate language.
Foundation Model	A broad AI model trained on diverse data that can be adapted to many tasks.
Machine Learning (ML)	A subset of AI where systems learn patterns from data rather than being explicitly programmed.
Deep Learning	A machine learning technique using neural networks with many layers.

Neural Network	A computational model inspired by the human brain used in many AI systems.

AI Interaction Terms

Term	Simple Definition
Prompt	The instructions or questions provided to an AI system.
Prompt Engineering	Crafting prompts to produce more accurate or useful outputs.
Context Window	The amount of information an AI can consider in a single interaction.
Inference	The process of generating an output from a trained AI model.
Fine-Tuning	Additional training of an AI model for a specific purpose.
Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG)	AI that retrieves external information before generating a response.
AI Agent	An AI system capable of planning and performing tasks with limited human supervision.
Human-in-the-Loop	A process where humans review, approve, or guide AI outputs.

Output Quality, Risk & Policy Terms

Term	Simple Definition
Hallucination	AI generating incorrect or fabricated information presented as fact.
Bias	Systematic unfairness or skewed outcomes in AI-generated results.

Accuracy	How correct the AI's output is.
Reliability	How consistently the AI performs as expected.
Explainability	The ability to understand how an AI reached a conclusion.
Transparency	Openness about how AI is developed, trained, or used.
Sanitization / Sanitized	The deliberate process of removing all Personally Identifiable Information (PII), student-identifying data, and sensitive operational details from a text before inputting it into an AI tool.
Validation	Confirming AI-generated information makes logical, practical, and operational sense before use (**The "Reality" Check**).
Verify / Verification	Checking AI-generated information against trusted, official sources, such as AFIs and Joint Publications, to ensure factual compliance (**The "Rule" Check**).

Section 2: Tool Authorization and Governance

Squadron Officer School (SOS) aligns its use of Artificial Intelligence (AI) platforms with approved enterprise tools and established local governance processes. To ensure security, data privacy, and operational integrity, all personnel must adhere to the categorized use of AI tools as defined in this policy.

SOS maintains a localized governance process to continually review, vet, and update the list of approved and experimental tools. Personnel are responsible for verifying the current authorization status of any AI tool prior to use by consulting the [Insert Reference/Link to Official Tool Roster or IT Portal].

To provide clear guidance on the application of AI within our organization, all AI tools and platforms are classified into three distinct categories: Approved, Experimental, and Prohibited.

Primary & Accredited AI Platforms

Gen AI Government Model (GenAI.mil) is the official, fully accredited Generative AI platform for SOS. All personnel are strongly encouraged to use the Gen AI Government Model as their primary tool for task automation, drafting, data analysis, and general operational support. This platform has undergone full security, privacy, and compliance vetting, ensuring data processed within it meets government protection standards.

Discretionary Use of Secondary AI Tools

Employees may utilize other commercially available third-party AI models on a discretionary basis for general, non-sensitive workflow support, provided the following conditions are met:

Data Protection: No non-public data, Personally Identifiable Information (PII), confidential agency records, or internal security documentation may be entered into discretionary tools.

Individual Accountability: Staff remain strictly accountable for reviewing, fact-checking, and validating all outputs before relying on or distributing AI-generated content.

Compliance: Use must align with standard acceptable use policies for software and web applications.

Prohibited AI Platforms

The use of Claude—including all free, paid, web, or API variants—is strictly prohibited across all SOS devices, networks, and official business activities until further notice. Employees must not input any agency assets or conduct SOS work within prohibited platforms.

Agency Disclaimer of Responsibility

Limitation of Liability: SOS assumes no responsibility or liability for the outputs, accuracy, bias, errors, or security risks associated with third-party or discretionary AI models. Employees use non-official AI tools strictly at their own discretion. Any decision, communication, or work product generated by or derived from a discretionary AI tool is the sole responsibility of the employee using it.

Section 3: Information Protection

To ensure compliance with federal law and military directives, faculty must understand the regulatory foundation behind these policies.

Air Force Privacy & PII: AFI 33-332 (Air Force Privacy and Civil Liberties Program)

The Law: Air Force Instruction 33-332 mandates the strict protection of Personally Identifiable Information (PII) to prevent identity theft and privacy violations.

The Risk: Uploading names, ranks, social details, or unique personal stories found in student reflective papers to external servers violates PII protection rules.

Policy Compliance: All inputs must be completely **sanitized** before submission to any approved GenAI system.

Operational Security & Controlled Unclassified Information: DoDI 5200.48 (CUI)

The Law: Department of Defense Instruction 5200.48 establishes the standards for identifying, safeguarding, and disseminating Controlled Unclassified Information (CUI).

The Risk: Officer-students frequently write about real-world unit vulnerabilities, specific weapon system maintenance issues, or leadership challenges. While not classified, the compilation of these details often

constitutes CUI. Public AI tools scrape and retain data, leading to severe "data leakage" risks outside of military control.

Policy Compliance: No CUI may be entered into public, commercial GenAI tools.

Section 4: Student Use Standards

The following seven levels provide a framework for how AI might be employed in various contexts; these levels can be used at the individual assignment level, at the course level, or more broadly. Regardless of level of GenAI use, it is the user's responsibility to verify the accuracy of the results and document level of use. Note that providing transcripts typically requires logging into an account.

Seven Levels of Possible GenAI Usage*
Higher levels authorize permission for all lower levels unless otherwise stated by the instructor. Specific examples for each level are provided below the table.

	Level descriptor	**What this looks like in practice:**
Level 0	No use of GenAI	Captains will create their own, original work without the use of GenAI in any manner.
Level 1	Organizational / Explanatory use of GenAI	The use of GenAI for personal efficiency (i.e., summarizing notes / readings, clarifying content) is acceptable; however, Captains will create their own, original work without the use of GenAI for submitted assignments. *If later used to support an assignment, this use should be acknowledged in documentation statements.*
Level 2	Use of GenAI for brainstorming or idea generation	Captains may consult GenAI as a tool for initial brainstorming or idea generation, but are expected to create their own, original work without the use of GenAI. *Use of GenAI in this manner should be acknowledged as part of documentation statements as described by the instructor.*
Level 3	Use of GenAI as a feedback tool on student-generated work	Captains create their own work independently, then may use GenAI as a tool to get feedback about their work (similar to what an instructor might give, e.g., suggestions for improvement, clarification, alignment with the assignment instructions, or editing tips). Captains are expected to make their own revisions based on this feedback. *The Captain should document how and where GenAI was used in their process, potentially including prompts and full transcripts as instructed.*
Level 4	Use of GenAI to cocreate and/or revise work	Captains may use GenAI to develop drafts, outlines, or provide suggested revisions to their drafts, but they must critically evaluate, revise, and take ownership of the content. Submitted work should reflect the Captain's understanding, not unedited AI output. *This use of GenAI must be clearly documented as instructed, specifying how GenAI contributed and what the Captain did to revise or evaluate that content.*

Level 5	Unrestricted, attributed use of GenAI	Captains may submit work that includes unedited or heavily AIgenerated content. The emphasis is on transparency, not authorship. *The extent and nature of GenAI use must be clearly disclosed with proper attribution in a documentation statement as described by the instructor.*
Level 6	Unrestricted, unattributed use of GenAI	While it is possible to use GenAI in an unrestricted manner without attribution, any who apply this level in their course should carefully consider ethical and legal implications.

* These suggested levels were modified from those adopted at Illinois State University.

Examples of each level of possible GenAI use:

- **Level 0 (No use)**: Captains will work using source documents, texts, and other materials provided or permitted by the instructor. They should not utilize web searches because GenAI now provides automatic summaries when browsers are queried.
- **Level 1 (Organizational/Explanatory Use):** A Captain asks GenAI to create a study guide or flashcards or Quizlet questions for the major terms in a reading assignment, and then provides the list of terms to GenAI. OR, A Captain asks GenAI to explain a concept they are confused about, and then provides the GenAI with the topic/concept about which they are confused.
- **Level 2 (Idea Generation Use):** A Captain provides GenAI with the instructions for a final project in an applied statistics course where they have to learn a new method and apply it to a dataset. The Captain then asks GenAI to help generate a few ideas for methods to learn, based on a list of their interests so far in the course. OR, A Captain asks GenAI to list some possible angles the Captain could take for a policy memo on reducing energy consumption in military housing. The Captain documents how and where GenAI was used in their process, potentially including prompts and full transcripts as instructed.
- **Level 3 (Feedback Tool Use):** A Captain writes an essay, asks GenAI for feedback on clarity and structure, and then makes their own edits based on the suggestions. OR, A Captain writes some code and then asks GenAI to point out areas where the code could be streamlined; the Captain then focuses on those areas and determines how to make the revisions to improve the code. The Captain documents how and where GenAI was used in their process, potentially including prompts and full transcripts as instructed.
- **Level 4 (Co-create Use):** A Captain is assigned to write a policy memo. They ask GenAI to generate an initial draft based on a prompt they provide, then review the AI-generated content, identify inaccuracies, rewrite large portions, and revise the structure to meet assignment criteria. The final submission reflects the Captain's own reasoning, edits, and understanding—not a direct copy of the AI output. The Captain documents how and where GenAI was used in their process, potentially including prompts and full transcripts as instructed.
- **Level 4 (Revision Suggestions Use):** A Captain writes a full draft of a leadership reflection essay. Before submitting it, they paste the draft into GenAI and ask for suggestions to improve clarity and structure of the essay. GenAI provides several suggestions, including reordering paragraphs and rephrasing unclear sentences. The Captain reviews each suggestion, accepts some, rewrites others in their own words, and rejects the rest. The final submission reflects the Captain's voice and understanding, not the AI's. The Captain documents how and where GenAI was used in their process, potentially including prompts and full transcripts as instructed.
- **Level 5 (Creation by GenAI Use):** A Captain uses GenAI to generate full paragraphs for a literature review and includes the paragraphs in their paper with minimal revision. The Captain adds a footnote and clearly documents how and where AI was used based on the course requirements. OR, A Captain uses GenAI to write most of the R code for a statistics project, or asks GenAI to generate all visuals for a final project presentation. The Captain documents how

and where GenAI was used in their process, potentially including prompts and full transcripts as instructed.

- **Mixed level assignment:** The first step of a multi-step project incorporates a brainstorming stage for which Captains are allowed to use GenAI to help come up with initial ideas (Level 2). They are allowed to use GenAI to provide feedback on their first draft but they should not use GenAI to generate any parts of that draft (Level 3). They also engage in peer feedback on the first drafts during which they should not use GenAI at all (Level 0). They apply feedback from GenAI and peers to write their final version for grading with no additional use of GenAI (Level 3 continued).

***Mixed level course:** An instructor might set the default course level to Level 1, allowing Captains to use GenAI to explain concepts that confuse them or to create podcasts that overview the readings. However, the instructor might also create an assignment with primary source readings that they want Captains to learn to read and interpret on their own, and thus, that assignment would be labeled Level 0

Section 5: Faculty Use Standards

Faculty members are academic leaders and military role models. To make implementation seamless, avoid logical conflicts, and allow simple "short-code" designations, the faculty framework is divided into two distinct, parallel operational phases: **Curriculum Creation** utilizing numbers 0 through 3, and **Student Evaluation** utilizing letters Z through D.

Universal Faculty Rules

The Human-in-the-Loop Grading Rule (Level C): Instructors may use secure GenAI tools to help analyze student submissions, draft rubric scores, and suggest provisional marks, but are strictly prohibited from letting GenAI assign final grades. The human instructor remains the sole, final grading authority. No grade may be officially recorded without direct human review and sign-off.

Phase Independence & Cumulative Rules

Permissions are cumulative *within* each framework (e.g., authorization at Level 2 permits Level 1 and 0; authorization at Level B permits Levels A and Z).

Permissions do *not* cross frameworks (e.g., being authorized at Level 2 for assignment creation does *not* authorize an instructor to use Level B for student feedback). Each phase must be explicitly designated for every assignment using the standard alphanumeric code (e.g., "1-A").

The Security Ceiling: Higher levels *never* bypass federal security protocols. Personally Identifiable Information (PII) and Controlled Unclassified Information (CUI) must always be sanitized before utilizing any GenAI tool.

Alphanumeric Labeling Protocol (How to Combine Matrices)

To establish an assignment's explicit AI profile, curriculum developers select **one number** from the Curriculum Creation matrix and **one letter** from the Student Evaluation matrix. This creates a simple, two-character designation (e.g., **1-A**, **2-C**, or **0-Z**) that is printed on the assignment sheet.

Practical Examples of Matrix Labeling:

1. **Example 1: Label "1-A" (Active Prep & Draft Review)**
    a. **Curriculum Level 1 (Brainstorm):** The instructor used Gemini to generate general ideas for a mock leadership crisis scenario but wrote the entire prompt manually.
    b. **Evaluation Level A (Review Drafts):** The instructor is authorized to upload sanitized student essay drafts to a secure GenAI tool to scan for structural and organization issues before final submission.
    c. *Resulting Label:* **1-A**
2. **Example 2: Label "2-C" (Co-Authored Prep & Grading Assistance)**
    a. **Curriculum Level 2 (Co-Author):** The instructor used GenAI to co-write case study details, proofread assignment instructions, or structure a custom evaluation rubric.
    b. **Evaluation Level C (Grading Advisor):** The instructor is authorized to input sanitized student submissions and rubrics into Gemini for Government to draft initial feedback and suggest provisional grades, which the human instructor must review, customize, and approve.
    c. *Resulting Label:* **2-C**
3. **Example 3: Label "0-Z" (The "Absolute Zero" Security State)**
    a. **Curriculum Level 0 (No Use):** The curriculum was built entirely by human hands from primary sources with zero AI footprint due to the high-stakes or classified nature of the topic.
    b. **Evaluation Level Z (No Use):** The student work must be read and graded entirely manually with zero AI involvement, ensuring highly personal leadership mentorship or protecting sensitive student anecdotes.
    c. *Resulting Label:* **0-Z**

Curriculum Creation Framework (Levels 0-3)

Governs how instructors use GenAI to design, build, and prepare curriculum materials before they are handed to students.

Level	Workflow Step	Plain-English Translation (Copy to Assignment Headers)	Acceptable Usage Examples	Unacceptable Usage Examples	Policy Guidance & Restrictions
Level 0	**No Use**	*"Your instructor did not use GenAI in the creation, drafting, or design of this assignment."*	Writing an entire assignment outline, case study, and syllabus purely from human military experience and primary sources.	Copying ideas, templates, or phrases from any GenAI model to construct the prompt.	**STRICT CONTROL.** Zero AI footprint in the development of the course content. Used for high-stakes operational planning or sensitive tactical scenarios.
Level 1	**Brainstorm**	*"Your instructor used GenAI to brainstorm initial lesson concepts and fictional scenarios for this assignment."*	Generating ideas for a mock leadership crisis scenario. Brainstorming seminar discussion starter questions.	Directly copy-pasting unedited AI outputs into the final assignment prompt or syllabus.	**PERMISSIBLE.** Brainstorming only. Instructor must heavily edit, expand, and adapt all ideas. No disclosure required.

Level 2	**Co-Author**	*"Your instructor used GenAI to co-author and refine this assignment prompt, syllabus detail, or rubric."*	Using GenAI to draft case study details, proofread prompt instructions, or clean up rubric formatting.	Publishing co-created materials without verifying citations against official publications.	**PERMISSIBLE WITH COMPLIANCE.** Requires verification against AFIs and Joint Pubs. No disclosure required *if* heavily edited by human.
Level 3	**Unrestricted**	*"Your instructor utilized unrestricted GenAI toolsets to automate the administration and logistics of this course."*	Optimizing classroom schedules, organizing task flows, or translating administrative formatting.	Drafting student-facing evaluation prompts without human review or alignment.	**ADMINISTRATIVE UTILITY.** Authorized for general admin prep. No formal student-facing disclosure required.

Student Evaluation Framework (Levels Z-D)

Governs how instructors use GenAI to interact with, review, and evaluate student work after it has been submitted.

Level	Workflow Step	Plain-English Translation (Copy to Assignment Headers)	Acceptable Usage Examples	Unacceptable Usage Examples	Policy Guidance & Restrictions

Level Z	**No Use**	*"Your instructor will evaluate, review, and grade your work without any assistance from GenAI tools."*	Reading, grading, and writing paper feedback entirely manually with ink or digital stylus notes.	Uploading student papers to any external program, secure or insecure, to scan for spelling or structure.	**STRICT CONTROL.** Zero AI footprint in evaluation. Used for sensitive personal reflection papers, peer assessments, or high-security topics.
Level A	**Review Drafts**	*"Your instructor may use secure GenAI to scan drafts and identify structural issues in your writing."*	Scanning a **sanitized** student essay draft to identify high-level structural weaknesses.	Uploading un-sanitized essays containing PII, unit numbers, or unique operational anecdotes.	**STRICTLY CONTROLLED.** Requires 100% data sanitization of student papers. Only allowed to detect high-level structure.
Level B	**Make Feedback**	*"Your instructor may use GenAI to help generate feedback suggestions, but a human reviews and delivers all final comments."*	Drafting constructive criticism, formatting, or grammar suggestions to help students revise work.	Copy-pasting raw AI feedback blocks directly to a student without instructor customization.	**STRICTLY CONTROLLED.** Requires 100% data sanitization. Mandatory disclosure to students. Humans must approve and customize feedback.

Level C	**Grading Advisor**	*"Your instructor may use secure GenAI to draft rubric evaluations and suggest provisional grades, but a human instructor reviews all submissions and makes the final grading decisions."*	Uploading a **sanitized** essay and assignment rubric to obtain a suggested grade breakdown, structural feedback, or rubric score drafts.	Inputting student essays containing PII. Directly exporting AI-generated scores to the official gradebook without a human review.	**STRICTLY CONTROLLED (Human-in-the-Loop).** Requires 100% data sanitization. AI may only serve as an advisor. Human is the final authority.
Level D	**Unrestricted**	*"Unrestricted or automated grading/evaluation by GenAI is strictly prohibited."*	None. (This level serves as a policy ceiling to prevent automated evaluations).	Letting AI grade essays or assignments without a human instructor reviewing the work.	**PROHIBITED FOR COURSEWORK.** Kept as a policy boundary to prevent compliance drift. No student evaluation may use Level D.

Section 6: Disclosure Requirements & Communication

To ensure mutual accountability, every assignment prompt published at SOS must feature a **Reciprocal Transparency Header** that maps student expectations, faculty creation methods, and faculty evaluation limits side-by-side.

Student Use Disclosure

Captain Documentation Statements: As they do with other sources, Captains should document their use of GenAI. Common best practices include requirements to identify which GenAI tool was used, the transcript showing the specific prompts used and the resultant outputs, and an explanation of how the GenAI output was evaluated, revised, and incorporated into the final product. Additionally, it is good practice to archive these transcripts at least until grades have been submitted in case there are later any questions. Furthermore, it is recommended for instructors to clearly state in their course policies how they will handle insufficient documentation of GenAI use.

Example statement on an assignment for Captains: You will be asked to provide an explanation and reflection of how GenAIs were used on various assignments in this course. Be certain to document this tool as you would any other additional resource, and NEVER attempt to pass off someone or something else's work as your own. Your documentation statement should include 1) what you provided the GenAI and an explanation of your prompts, 2) what the GenAI provided you and an explanation of the output, and 3) how you altered the GenAI's output (e.g., how you iterated on prompts or how you edited the response before using it). A full transcript of your interaction with the GenAI should be provided whenever possible.

Mandatory Assignment Header Template

Curriculum developers must insert this exact header block at the top of every assignment sheet. For example, an assignment built with brainstorming and evaluated via draft review would display a profile code of **1-A**.

USAGE POLICY FOR THIS ASSIGNMENT

STUDENT PERMISSION LEVEL	CURRICULUM CREATION & STUDENT EVALUATION FRAMEWORK
Level	Level (Insert Code, e.g.,1−A,2−C, or 0−Z)

The use of GenAI outside of these boundaries by either party constitutes an academic integrity or operational security violation.

Standard Faculty Feedback & Grading Disclosure (For Level B & Level C)

When an instructor uses GenAI to assist in drafting qualitative feedback suggestions (Level B) or generating rubric advice (Level C), they must append the following disclosure to the student's rubric:

"Your submission was reviewed for structural clarity and rubric alignment with the assistance of GENAI (Gemini for Government). The resulting assessment suggestions and feedback drafts have been fully verified, customized, and finalized by your human instructor, who remains the sole authority for your grade."

Section 7: Communication Procedures
Section 8: Misuse and Adjudication
Section 9: Review Process

FIRST M. LAST, Rank, USAF

Aim High